Chemicals professionally; neither did he set much store by the need to establish institutional structures. ‘Seth ran Tata Chemicals almost as a personal fiefdom’ and in an ‘extremely individualistic manner’, wrote a business newspaper in 1997. In July 1992, he installed his son, Manu Seth, as his successor, similar to a ‘dynastic rule’, added the daily. Darbari himself continued as the chairman till March 1994.

Ratan succeeded Seth as the chairman of Tata Chemicals and ushered in sweeping changes across its entire spectrum. During this phase, the company’s revenue grew nearly twenty-eight times, at a pace of almost one and a half times every year. The robust growth was propelled primarily by the various restructuring policies rolled out by Ratan as the group chairman. After adopting these policies, Tata Chemicals achieved a faster pace than most other Tata Group companies.

Ratan adopted a twin-pronged approach for Tata Chemicals. The first was the implementation of the structural reforms under the TBEM process, branding agreement, amongst others, and the second, the aggressive implementation of select components of the modified Strategic Plan.

For instance, to achieve higher scores in the assessment matrices of the JRD QV Award and TBEM processes, Tata Chemicals embraced several steps. These included Manthan (churning), a process that helped cut costs and improve efficiency; and Unnati (progress) that assured shop-floor excellence and consisted of special training programmes. ‘These efforts worked magic for Tata Chemicals’ and it was able to turn ‘itself around’. The processes ushered in a holistic change. There was a sharp focus on achieving excellence and reorienting its strategies for greater customer satisfaction.

These steps had to be aggressively pursued as everything was not well with the company when Ratan assumed its chairmanship. Initially, it did not measure well in the JRD QV assessment matrices. In 2000, it scored less than 50 per cent of what was required to qualify for the award, says R. Mukundan, MD of Tata Chemicals. But seven years later, the company came back to lift the award through its transformative policies. In doing so, it became the fifth company after Tata Steel, TCS, Titan and Tata Motors to win the award. In 2003, Tata Salt was ‘ranked [the] no.1 food brand in Brand Equity Survey of India’s most trusted brands’. This was evidence that the changes ushered in by the company to attain higher scores in the